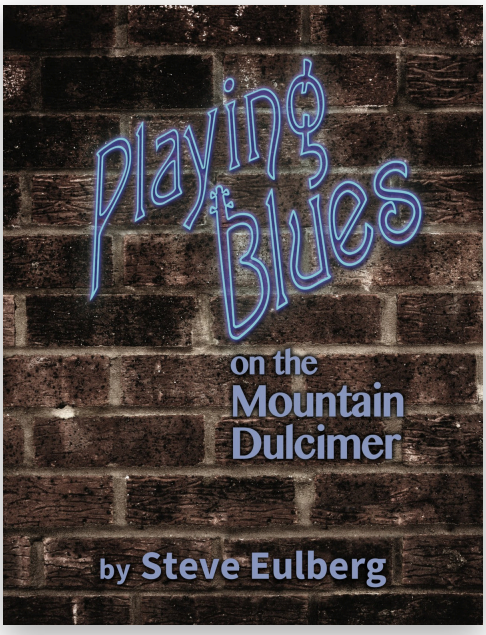
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Playing Blues On The Mountain Dulcimer

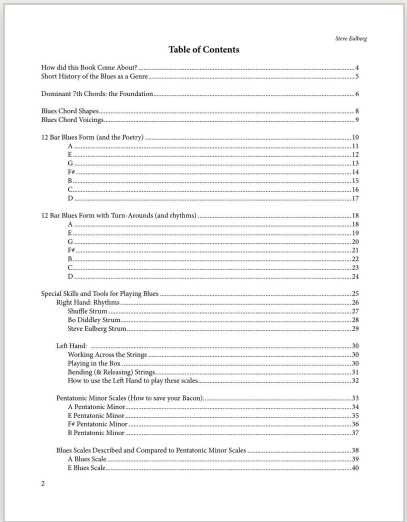
by Steve Eulberg



Playing Blues On The Mountain Dulcimer by jazz and blues performer Steve Eulberg proves a regular mountain dulcimer can play the blues.

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INSIDE THE BOOK

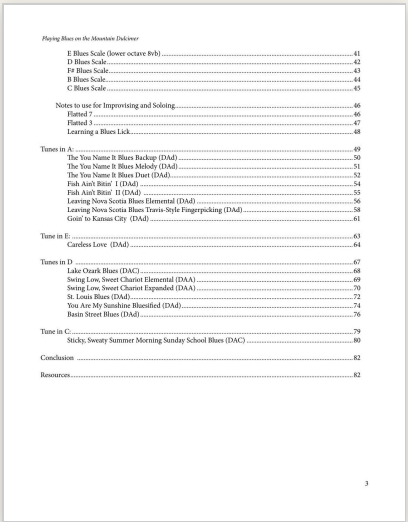


Steve Eulberg

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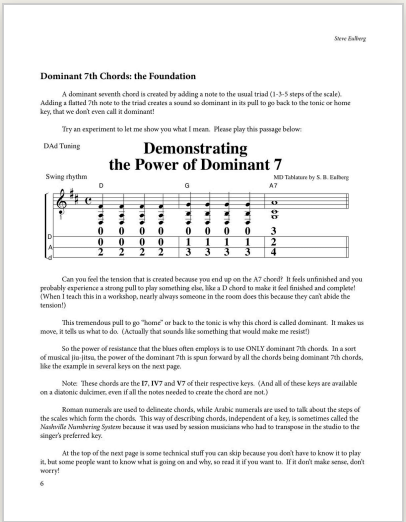
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Steve Eulberg

Dominant 7th Chords: the Foundation

A dominant seventh chord is created by adding a note to the usual triad (1-3-5 steps of the scale). Adding a flatted 7th note to the triad creates a sound so dominant in its pull to go back to the tonic or home key, that we don't even call it dominant!

Try an experiment to let me show you what I mean. Please play this passage below:

DAd Tuning

Demonstrating the Power of Dominant 7

Swing rhythm

Can you feel the tension that is created because you end up on the A7 chord? It feels unfinished and you probably experience a strong pull to play something else, like a D chord to make it feel finished and complete! (When I teach this in a workshop, nearly always someone in the room does this because they can't abide the tension!)

This tremendous pull to go "home" or back to the tonic is why this chord is called dominant. It makes us move, it tells us what to do. (Actually that sounds like something that would make me resist!)

So the power of resistance that the blues often employs is to use ONLY dominant 7th chords. In a sort of musical jiu-jitsu, the power of the dominant 7th is spun forward by all the chords being dominant 7th chords, like the example in several keys on the next page.

Note: These chords are the **I7, IV7** and **V7** of their respective keys. (And all of these keys are available on a diatonic dulcimer, even if all the notes needed to create the chord are not.)

Roman numerals are used to delineate chords, while Arabic numerals are used to talk about the steps of the scales which form the chords. This way of describing chords, independent of a key, is sometimes called the *Nashville Numbering System* because it was used by session musicians who had to transpose in the studio to the singer's preferred key.

At the top of the next page is some technical stuff you can skip because you don't have to know it to play it, but some people want to know what is going on and why, so read it if you want to. If it don't make sense, don't worry!

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